

Reading the Body

The consultation, the contraindications that must never be missed, and knowing where your practice ends

Learning Objectives

- Conduct a thorough pre-service health consultation before any body treatment begins
- Identify absolute contraindications that require declining a service entirely
- Identify relative contraindications that require adapting a service
- Explain why a health intake form is a safety instrument, not paperwork

The most consequential form in this Atelier's curriculum

No service in this course carries higher stakes if a health question is skipped than bodywork. A missed contraindication here does not risk an uneven cut or a mismatched shade — in rare but serious cases, it can genuinely endanger a client's health. Treat the consultation and intake form with the seriousness that reality deserves.

Absolute contraindications: decline the service

- **Deep vein thrombosis (DVT) or suspected blood clot.** Massage can dislodge a clot, risking a potentially fatal pulmonary embolism. Any undiagnosed swelling, warmth, and pain in one leg specifically is a medical emergency requiring immediate referral, not a leg massage.
- **Fever or active contagious illness.** Postpone the service until fully recovered.
- **Contagious skin conditions** (active fungal infection, impetigo, scabies, unhealed wounds). Decline until resolved.
- **Recent surgery in the treatment area**, without explicit medical clearance to proceed.

- **Severe, uncontrolled hypertension or recent cardiac event**, without medical clearance.

Relative contraindications: adapt the service

- **Pregnancy.** Adjust positioning and technique per Module Eight; avoid specific pressure points traditionally cautioned against in the first trimester.
- **Varicose veins.** Avoid direct, deep pressure over the vein itself; work around it gently instead.
- **Cancer history or active treatment.** Consult with the client's oncology team where possible; adapt pressure and technique per current oncology-massage guidance, which varies by treatment stage.
- **Diabetes.** Extra caution with pressure and temperature on the extremities, echoing the caution taught in Course IV.
- **Medication affecting bruising (blood thinners).** Reduce pressure significantly to avoid bruising a client who bruises far more easily than usual.

A Note from Practice

A client arrives for a relaxation massage and mentions, almost in passing, that one calf has been "a bit swollen and warm the last few days, probably just from the flight." This combination — unilateral swelling, warmth, and recent long-haul travel — is a recognised risk pattern for DVT, not a routine muscle complaint.

The correct response is not to proceed with a leg massage and hope it is nothing. It is to decline massage on that leg specifically, explain gently but seriously why, and recommend she see a doctor promptly — a conversation that may feel like an overreaction in the moment, and is, on rare occasions, the reason a serious complication is caught in time.

Key Terms

0

[object Object]

1

[object Object]

2

[object Object]

Practical Activity · The Intake Review

Complete a full health intake consultation with a partner or model, asking every question from this module's checklist aloud rather than silently reading a form. Identify whether anything disclosed would be an absolute or relative contraindication. **File this record; it is your first completed body consultation.**